Don't go wasting your emotion (lay all your love on me)

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by that_one_sleep_paralysis_demon

Summary

A modern Phaidei Hanahaki AU in which Phainon:
- Freaks out about having Hanahaki
- Tries to make Mydei hate him
- Yearns
- Regrets everything and has a breakdown in front of a 7/11 at one in the morning

Notes

So.. I dipped off the face of earth for a while and deleted my old fics. Look, I know the title is bad. I got it from an ABBA song bc I have no creativity whatsoever. Phaidei has single handedly resurrected me- I've been lurking around the fics for several months now and I'm here with my own offering to present to the Phaidei Council.

See the end of the work for more notes

- Translation into 中文-普通话 國語 available: 【授权翻译】别浪费你的感情（倾心于我） Don't go wasting your emotion (lay all your love on me) by min_tac

When the first blood stained white petal fell from his mouth, Phainon knew he was screwed, no, doomed. He'd been feeling off all week and now here he was in the school bathroom, trying to scrub the drops of blood off the bathroom sink with a sorry excuse for a tissue paper. It vaguely felt like he was cleaning up a crime scene.

The crime being his feelings for Mydei- the co- class president, captain of the sports team ,his rival and his best friend.

Brilliant.

It's not like he *asked* to fall so hard for his golden eyed rival. It kind of just… happened. One day, Mydei seemed to shine more than he usually did and then his presence itself made Phainon's heart rate spike to an unnatural extent and all Phainon could think of was Mydei every time they came into contact. Even then, it's not like Phainon's behaviour around Mydei changed a lot once he spent that one night sitting in the bathroom, mentally bashing himself over being so stupid as to fall for Mydei. They were still Mydei and Phainon, Phainon and Mydei. Competitors slash friends.

Their fellow students loved the rivalry between Mydei and Phainon, each forming their separate teams on who to support. Mydei called it stupid, scowling his signature 'death scowl' (Phainon dubbed it that, much to Mydei's chagrin) every time some student placed a bet on who would win the next contest. Phainon reveled in the attention, for it seemed that the student body loved him. He was someone who craved attention and thrill of validation like it was sustenance. To be loved and admired from a distance made him feel most like himself.

It didn't entirely fix the gaping void in his heart, the one that yearned for someone to see behind the precariously crafted facade of 'Phainon'. Someone he could drop the smile around and cry in front of. This hypothetical someone should always remain a distant wish, for Phainon did not truly deserve someone like that. He must give all of himself, and even then, that person would find a way to give him even more and he'd feel indebted to them.

But you take what you get and you don't complain, even if the stares of expectation feel like nails stabbed into your body. Even if the sting of loneliness feels like a dull ache in the back of your throat, threatening to choke you.

He was choking at that very moment, matter of fact, but it was the stupid petals that had lodged themselves in his throat. And it was all Mydei's fault.

He wanted to throttle and kiss Mydei at the same time.

Phainon gagged as he extracted one last petal from the roof of his mouth.His heart was hammering in his chest. Emotions that he thought he'd successfully suppressed and locked up were threatening to surge and devour him. He hadn't felt afraid in a long, long time and now, fear might just topple his house of cards.

He didn't want to think about his inevitable fate. Bloody flower petals meant Hanahaki disease and Hanahaki disease meant he was running out of time. He'd die of his unrequited love for Mydei or get surgery to completely forget about his feelings for the boy with the pretty gold eyes. Some selfish part of Phainon wanted to cling onto his feelings for Mydei, even if he would never look his way. It's not like he had the money to get the surgery, so was he just going to have to weather it out? Quite possibly. Just then, the bell rang, signaling the start of morning classes.

He straightened his tie, extra tight around his throat to look more put together, trying to distract himself from the tinny smell of iron. Externally, he was glowing. Internally? He was crumbling faster than his self respect when it came to Mydei.

He sauntered out of the bathroom as if he hadn't just been throwing up flower petals and having a mental breakdown a while ago. He popped his head into the classroom and his gaze immediately locked in on Mydei. Mydei sat near the window, reading a book, his strawberry blonde hair with red tips obscuring most of his face. Mydei was gorgeous- no, he was the reason why the word gorgeous was invented. He was tall and well built with a face that Phainon would go do unspeakable things for.

Never mind, Phainon wanted to brush the hair from his face tenderly and kiss him at the same time.

Phainon made his way over to Mydei and placed a hand on Mydei's chair, leaning over to see what Mydei was so engrossed in.

"Well, hello there, Mydei" Phainon greeted him cheerfully "Is that a Kremnoan history book?"

Mydei gave a noncommittal grunt as his response. Classic.

"The student council meeting will be at lunch. You'd better be there." Mydei said, finally looking up. Phainon could have sworn he ascended on the spot as Mydei locked eyes with him.

Phainon was a weak man to those eyes.

"Of course!" He chirped, finding his voice so that he wouldn't have to nod dumbly.

He flopped onto his seat, his mind screaming at him to *act normal*- whatever normal meant for him, at least.

He wasn't so sure of himself anymore.



As classes progressed, Phainon found it increasingly difficult to concentrate. His lungs felt constricted, the burn of the flowers making him feel restless. His head felt fuzzy, like it was stuffed with cotton, or maybe flowers, in Phainon's case. That joke should've made him laugh or at least crack a smile. Instead, it had the opposite effect, ringing in his head like a reminder that he was utterly, horribly screwed. When the time came to converse with his classmates and do his duties as class president, he smiled like he was programmed to do and did his best to be everyone's friend. He was Phainon, after all. Phainon never, *never* acted like anything was wrong. When his parents died when he was in middle school, Phainon sucked it up and showed up for the sports meet because he couldn't stand disappointing his teammates. He can still remember crying in the shower after they won the game, head throbbing and feeling feverish as he leaned against the cool tile.

In sixth period, he absentmindedly doodled chimeras with what little artistic talent he had on some loose sheets of paper. He was working on one when the bell for lunch rang. Unfortunately, he didn't notice the figure looming over his paper before it was too late.

"Deliverer, those chimeras look like they've been dropped in a vat of acid. Are you sure this isn't a cry for help?" Mydei asked, using that annoying nickname he'd sourced from a character in a series who he thought resembled Phainon.

"I- huh? What-" Phainon scrambled to hide the offending doodles and looked up at Mydei, somewhat alarmed. He wanted to curl up into a ball, disintegrate and be scattered by the wind.

"…"

Mydei scrutinized him for a minute before nodding in the direction of the Student Council room.

Oh. That.

Phainon trailed after him, eyes fixated on Mydei's blonde hair, itching to run his hands through it and maybe even braid it. As they walked, Phainon made sure to keep an endless stream of chatter with Mydei- talking about anything and everything while Mydei listened. It was a routine they'd fallen into since they were freshmen- Mydei listened and Phainon talked. Other times, they'd bicker and compete. It was safe, easy and familiar.

Aglaea, a senior and the head of the Student Council sat at the head of the table. She made the average high school senior look like a malformed bug in comparison to her. Top of the class, head of the Student Council and high profile designer in the making, Aglaea had it all. Seated opposite to her was the infamous Anaxa. He insisted that everyone call him Anaxagoras, but most people called him Anaxa, much to his annoyance. Part of the student council as head of the chemistry club (he insisted that it was the alchemy club), he and Aglaea weren't exactly on the best terms, just to put wanting to strangle each other nicely.

Castorice, a fellow junior who was in a different class, sat hunched over a notebook she always carried around. Phainon had tried to ask about the notebook's contents, but Castorice would shake her head and refuse to elaborate. She was the president of the art club, so he assumed that the notebook was filled with sketches she was too shy to show.

Mydei and Phainon slid into their seats next to each other- inseparable in a way Phainon used to be with Cyrene. Both of them were worthy candidates for the sports captain and class president, so they were told to team up for both.

"Hi, Cas! What are you drawing?" Phainon asked, trying to ignore the pain in his cheeks from smiling so much that day

"Oh. Uh, nothing" Castorice looked at the table, seeming very interested in following the cracks that lined the table. Her reaction reminded him of his own reactions to Mydei judging his doodles earlier. Although, Phainon could've sworn he saw a hand cupping someone else's face.

"Ah, Hyacine, good that you're here" Aglaea's voice cut through the air, snapping him out of his thoughts.

The bubblegum haired sophomore pushed open the door and waved at the Council. Phainon grinned and waved back at her.

"Alright, I have the documents for the sports fest this year. The refreshments and sports equipment have been accounted for." Hyacine read off a list

"Perfect. Phainon, Mydei, you two know the drill. Handle the selections and organise the events. I trust that you two will have this under control, yes?" Aglaea inquired

Phainon nodded eagerly, doing his best to not think of having to spend even more time with Mydei than he already did and risk getting his Hanahaki discovered.

"Yep! You can count on us"

"Yes" was all Mydei said.

Phainon could feel the flower petals rising in his lungs. Up till now, he'd just dealt with the discomfort of the petals, but now, he felt as though he might throw up. He stood up as calmly as he could considering he was seconds away from coughing up bloodied petals.

"I need to use the bathroom. See you guys later." Phainon announced in his most convincing happy voice he could muster and booked it out of the room. He didn't notice Mydei's concerned expression, having realised something was off.



It was getting worse. He coughed up even more flower petals than earlier in the morning, feeling horrible- not unlike trash on the side of the road. Phainon wiped his mouth and splashed some water on his face, trying to gaslight himself into thinking he's totally, one hundred percent fine. Yep, Nothing wrong.

"Did you just cough up a flower?"

Oh shit.

Phainon turned around slowly on his heel, like one of those scenes in horror movies where the protagonist goes *he's right behind me isn't he?* There was, in fact, a perplexed, no, concerned- Phainon couldn't pinpoint the emotion because of the eye patch covering one eye- Anaxa facing him. It was a rookie mistake, choosing to throw up in front of the sink.

"Uhh- no?" He stammered out

"No. That was a flower. I'm certain you just regurgitated a flower. You've either eaten the flowers in the garden Hyacine tends to or you have Hanahaki."

God damn it.

"Who is it then? The person you're pining after?"

"… nobody"

Phainon felt like he was being flayed open, like a specimen in a lab. Better yet, he felt like the frog he and Mydei dissected earlier that week in biology, its organs lined up neatly next to it the time they were done. He decided that he hated this feeling.

"You can't just expect me to believe you've fallen in love with a ghost." Anaxa paused, mulling over something before continuing with his thorough dissection of Phainon with his words."It's Mydeimos, isn't it?"

It sounded less like a question and more like a statement. Knowing Anaxa, it would be futile to argue.

"Yes."

Anaxa didn't even have the decency to act surprised. He just nodded like that was just a backing to his already correct assumptions.

"Now, you have two options- either confess your feelings to him and have him return them or get surgery. I'm sure you know about the consequences of not doing either."

Phainon, in the middle of his confusion and distress, wanted to laugh. Mydei, like *him* back? That was one of the most ridiculous statements he had ever heard. So the first option was crossed off in his mind instantly. He didn't even have the money for the surgery- the only

reason he could attend Okhema High was because of the scholarship that covered his living expenses as well as his tuition. Long story short, he was flat broke. Anaxa's uncovered eye bore into his soul, expecting an answer.

Oh Kephale, this was bad. It's not like he could just stop loving Mydei, not when every little interaction with Mydei made him fall for him all over again.

It was at this very moment that an idea struck him. He'd always been one for insane, often diabolical ideas, but this one took the cake.

What if he became Mydei's enemy and then got himself to hate Mydei so that the spread of the Hanahaki would stop and he'd fall out of love and get cured? It was an insane idea, yes. Did Phainon have serious attachment issues? Also yes. Did Phainon feel unworthy of being near Mydei- unworthy of loving him? Unfortunately, yes.

Even then, Phainon's confusion and fear addled brain decided that this would be the best course of action.

"Anaxa?"

"For the umpteenth time, it's *Anaxagoras*, you fool."

"Sorry, sorry- I won't do it again, Anaxa. Wait. Oh—"

"Forget it." Anaxa said delicately, barely concealing his murderous intent.

"Right. This is a hypothetical situation, okay? What if a person with Hanahaki started to hate the person they initially fell for? Would it possibly cure them?"

Anaxa narrowed his eyes but decided to play along.

"In theory, yes. Hate can cancel out love. However, it would take a different breed of a self-sabotaging moron to actually do that, though. Not when the best alternative is to get surgery."

Phainon chose to ignore the pointed look Anaxa was throwing at him. Anaxa wouldn't be able to understand- he wasn't desperate like Phainon was. He would never know what it was like to secretly take up jobs to have enough for his personal expenses, to be someone who had to come to school with a sunny, dependable smile and act like he didn't fail to pay the electricity bills for that month. Anaxa probably never knew what it felt like to be alone and so used to that hollow, all encompassing loneliness that losing another loved one was inevitable to him.

Mydei would leave Phainon eventually. He was everything Phainon would never be. The heir of Kremnos Industries, with a future as bright as he was. Mydei could fall any time, because someone would always catch him and hug him and tell him it was alright. Phainon couldn't afford to fall. To fail was to plunge into the abyss and have to scrape the bits of blood off his fingernails from trying too hard to hold on.

Mydei was a good thing and Phainon couldn't have good things.

"I'll think about it." was all Phainon could muster before heading out of the bathroom.



So began Phainon's elaborate plan of self sabotage. Was he going to destroy the best friendship he's ever had? Yes.

Phainon had begged the Mydei in his head for forgiveness over and over again. In his mind's eye, he had keeled onto the floor as he held Mydei's hand and cried, whispering apologies. Bringing his head to the floor, he'd crumpled in a ball and wished he never fell for Mydei to begin with- cursing himself for being so selfish. He'd then looked up at Mydei and pleaded for him to understand why he was doing what he was. He hated the thought that Mydei would be hurt by his own stupidity. This was probably reason number forty five why he hated himself as much as he did. Yes, he did indeed have a list, but that's besides the point.

He began to avoid Mydei like the plague, which was easier said than done, considering the fact that they were partnered up for everything from class presidency to organising the sports meet. In the end, he opted to stop talking and making eye contact with Mydei, It killed him to see Mydei look up expectantly when Phainon entered the classroom only to watch as Phainon walked right by him without so much as a glance. When Mydei would approach him for something that wasn't related to the sports meet or the class, Phainon would get up and walk away.

The past two weeks of Phainon's life were a mess. He missed Mydei terribly, to his own fault, he reminded himself as he blocked Mydei's number (my day mouse, it said- he was particularly proud of that name). Each day was a struggle as number of white petals he coughed up increased.

Brilliant.

Now Phainon was broke, miserable and Mydei- less(A term he came up while trying to describe the pit in his stomach and the emptiness in the air that surrounded him)

The rest of the student council had noticed the duo separated and Phainon was questioned about this new development a few times. Cipher had asked him if they were in the midst of a lover's quarrel, which Phainon shut down as quickly as he could. The other students had caught on to the fact that the two weren't talking anymore as well. Rumors floated around all the time, some of which Phainon was unfortunate enough to stumble upon.

"They must've broken up!"

"But I don't think they were dating"

"Then they must've fought!"

"But what kind of fight could drive those two apart?"

Phainon did his best to appear unbothered as he walked by the group, his head held high.

Mydei seemed to have decided to talk it out with Phainon and corner him at any chance he got. Phainon would ignore Mydei if he broached the topic of them not speaking as they prepared for the sports meet. He'd refuse to talk about anything else on purpose. Each time, Mydei would groan in frustration and eventually give up on trying to pry answers from Phainon's sealed lips. On other duty unrelated situations, he found creative ways to avoid Mydei. Creative by his definition, at least.

Which is how they ended up sprinting through the halls at 8 in the morning.

"Get back here, HKS. I need answers!" Mydei yelled as he chased Phainon down the stairs.

"I'm sorry! It's not you, it's me!"

"The hell do you mean?"

"I messed up and now I- ugh- I can't do this right now! I'm running!"

"Then stop running!"

"Then stop chasing me!"

It was Phainon's fault for bumping into the homeroom teacher at that very moment because the next thing he knew, he and Mydei were sentenced to detention. *Really, as class presidents and sports captains, you should be ashamed of yourselves*, the teacher had berated them before allowing them into the class. The day slugged by, Phainon trying to be as inconspicuous with his periodic visits to cough out lungfuls of petals.

Phainon got to the detention room first and collapsed on a chair near the window. He was exhausted and had been for a while now. He slouched and pulled the hood of his jacket up, wishing the floor would swallow him up.

"Phainon?" Castorice's voice came from behind the door as it creaked open. She must've passed by and spotted him

"You're here because of the detention you and Mydei got for running in the halls and causing a ruckus, aren't you?"

"Yeah."

"What.. happened? It's not like you two to just stop talking to each other like that. You're too close to ever do that."

Phainon wanted to confess everything, wanted to finally tell someone the bitter pain he'd been forcing himself to swallow over and over again.

On the first day of the plan, Phainon had written down four simple steps to make Mydei hate him-

Step 1: avoid him

Step 2: tell people you hate him; express that you think of him as your enemy

Step 3: watch as he hates you and stops trying to figure out what's wrong.

Step 4: lose your feelings for him and cure yourself of your Hanahaki

He'd accomplished step 1, so it should be time to begin with step 2 - telling people he hated Mydei.

"Mydei and I, we can't be friends, Cas. We're too different. He's a rich heir with all the money in the world and I'm nothing at all. I just- I just hung out with him because it was convenient for me. I don't actually like him. I just happened to gain some dignity and decide to leave him."

Phainon could not believe the words coming out of his own mouth. He regretted every last word he said, but he was too far in it now. It was like the voice he heard wasn't really his and the real Phainon was somewhere in his mind, slamming the floor and beseeching him to stop talking.

Midway through his tirade, Castorice looked like she was about to say something and then startled, gawking at the door. Phainon belatedly realised why she looked so alarmed.

There he was, as radiant as ever. Mydeimos, standing at the door, his jaw set, eyebrows scrunched and looking the closest thing to heartbroken as Phainon's ever seen.

Phainon had never hated himself more than he did in that moment.

"Go. Follow him" Castorice urged, looking more angry and distressed than Phainon had ever seen her. Hell, he'd thought that the mild mannered Castorice was incapable of feeling anger up until that point.

Phainon's mind was a jumbled mess of *whatthehelldidyoudoyouidiot* and *ihateyouihateyouihateyou* reverberating through his skull. His heart felt like it was throbbing against his ribcage as he rounded a corner in the school garden where he and Mydei liked to play fight. Mydei was already standing there, the golden eyes that reminded him of the blazing sun meeting his own.

"…Phainon"

That was the one of the rare times Mydei had called Phainon by his name. In any other situation, he would have savoured the moment and held it close to his heart and never let go. Just not in this one, because Mydei's voice was the only thing he could hear apart from the TV static buzzing in his mind.

"A rich heir with all the money in the world. Is that all you see me as? A convenience? Someone you just stuck around with and never even saw as a friend?"

"No- I-"

"Phainon. Please. Don't lie. *Tell* me, what did these two years mean to you?"

"That wasn't what I meant- I didn't mean to phrase it like that. It was just the situation, the wrong thing slipped out and- oh Kephale, I have no excuses. I mean, look at you and look at me. What would any rational person think when they see us side- by - side? The heir of Kremnos Industries next to some charity case of a country boy- that's what they'd see." Phainon spat the words out like they were acid on his tongue, acid he'd inevitably spew.

Phainon must have imagined the flicker of pain in Mydei's eyes, like he was wishing this was all a bad dream. There was a long pause in which Phainon was certain he'd done it- pushed away yet another person he loved. *This is for the best*, a voice in his head whispered, *you wanted this, you wanted to make him hate you*. Finally, Mydei spoke, in a voice that lacked his usual quiet confidence- hell, he looked *hurt.*

"Since when have you ever been lesser than I?"

Phainon felt sick to his stomach. A wave of nausea threatened to crawl up his stomach and his throat felt like it was being crushed. (Maybe that was the stupid flowers, Phainon hoped he didn't start coughing them up right then and there) Why didn't Mydei hate him yet? Why was Mydei hurt instead of angry? Phainon wanted to say something to placate Mydei, but he knew he would recognise his lies as though Phainon was made out of see- through glass.

When Phainon stared mutely at Mydei, Mydei scoffed - not derisively, but defeatedly. He must have understood the meaning of his silence.

I am not and never will be an equal to you.

"So be it. Phainon of Aedes Elysiae, you were the first person who could best me. I was foolish to believe you thought of me the way I do you."

A pause

"Goodbye."

With that, Mydei walked away, leaving Phainon clutching at his shattered heart. His lungs burned as he ducked behind a wall and coughed up a whole, bloodstained lily.



It had been a day since the incident. Mydei, true to his word, didn't so much as look at Phainon the entire rest of the day. Phainon felt despondent as he trudged back into the small flat the scholarship had provided him with. On Saturday. his phone buzzed with a reminder for Tuesday's meeting with Mydei to finalise some details for the sports meet. He had no idea how he was going to face Mydei again after what he said and did. Phainon spent the entire day moping and occasionally crying as he made himself instant noodles because that was all he knew to make. He was a wreck, to put it lightly. His phone did occasionally buzz with texts from Castorice asking if he was alright, all of which he felt guilty for ignoring.

Lilies tore out of Phainon's lungs as he hunched over the toilet, the flower's smooth petals akin to sandpaper. The steady dripping of blood into the toilet bowl was the thing he chose to focus on to ground himself.

Phainon was certain he was going to die. Of his feelings for Mydei, no less.

It seemed as though the plan to make Mydei hate him and to grow to become his enemy had failed miserably. The only person he could bring himself to hate was himself. He made a mental note to never, ever make plots of any shape or form ever again.

Monday rolled around and Phainon knew that no amount of pep talks or gas-lighting himself to think everything was fine would fix the mess he made. Mydei did show up that day, albeit a bit delayed, which was strange considering his stellar reputation for being punctual. Phainon's day felt like a fever dream; he chatted and laughed and smiled until his cheeks hurt, but he didn't remember much else. After school, he decided to find Castorice and apologise for involving her in the mess and dismissing her concern.

Man, he felt like such a bad friend.

He got to the art club, but her seat was empty. He was about to turn around and search for her elsewhere, but her sketchbook caught his eye. In his defense, the sketchbook was open and covered only by a pencil pouch. Maybe he was so out of it that common decency evaded him, but he moved the pencil pouch aside to peer into the book.

In front of him lay sketches of him and Mydei. That wouldn't be a problem if not for the less than platonic way in which they held each other. A flush crept up his cheeks and ears.

Well, at least Phainon now knew whose hands were cupping whose face.

A strangled gasp brought him out of his thoughts. Castorice looked like she would give anything to yeet herself out the window and into the bushes below.

"Oh- I- I'm so sorry, I don't know what came over me" Phainon tried to piece together an apology that would make him sound less like an asshole.

"No- did you *see* any of that?"

"Yes, but I swear I didn't mean too. Promise, Cas."

A long pause followed. Castorice was the first to break it.

"Do you hate me now?"

"I beg your pardon?"

"I drew stuff of you and Mydei that I probably shouldn't have and I think I offended you."

"What? No, no you didn't. I'm not offended or creeped out out or mad. I was just surprised to see those sketches- not that I mind them, of course. I think you depicted my charming smile quite well." Phainon cracked a joke and smiled his signature confident smile to lighten the mood.

"Oh. You actually don't mind me shipping you two and drawing you and Mydei.. uh- you know, kissing?"

"No, not at all. I'm kind of glad that we're together in some form. But Mydei would never look at me like that. Like he loves me."

Castorice looked at him curiously, as though he had somehow evolved and grown a new set of limbs.

"What makes you think he doesn't already do that?"

Phainon wanted to truly laugh for the first time that day because of how ridiculous he found the notion. Phainon loved Mydei. That was a certainty, like how the earth revolved the sun and night would come after day. But in no way could, no, *should* Mydei ever love Phainon.

He knew he wasn't worthy of the gaze of the burning sun.

"Well, even in a far off, near impossible, hypothetical situation where he did like me, I don't think he'd like me any more. Not after what I said to him."

"Phainon, he misses you"

As much as Phainon would have liked to deny that, he knew that he and Mydei were too close for Mydei to not miss him. That only made him feel worse. He hurt someone who actually cared. He went and stomped over Mydei's feelings like the monster he was and made Mydei feel like he was never wanted.



Phainon couldn't sleep that night- the fan wasn't working because his electricity got cut off for the fifth time in the past week. The churning in his stomach made him feel nauseous and seconds away from throwing up the sad excuse for a sandwich he had for dinner. He hacked up lilies occasionally as he tossed and turned. When he finally couldn't take it, he pulled on a hoodie and a pair of shoes and headed over to the run down 7/11 located at the corner of the street.

He bought himself a small packet of pomegranate juice and sat on a bench outside the store. He didn't even realise he bought pomegranate juice before he took a sip and a feeling that felt like nostalgia mixed with a deep, intense yearning constricted his throat. No matter how much Phainon hated it, he loved it even more; it was the closest thing he's gotten to home since Mydei.

Home first meant the small town of Aedes Elysiae. It meant his parents and his sister Cyrene's warm smiles and even warmer embraces. Next, it meant Mydei. Mydei, who turned from a rival to a friend he could always depend on. Mydei, whose presence spoke louder than the words he rarely said.

Why did he have to push him away?

Phainon was sure that nobody would expect him to be this broken and *wrong*. He was all jagged edges and sharp ends, ready to lash out if someone tried to see past his facade. It seemed like the facade did work out, so at least he had the reassurance that something in his life went right.

Nobody knew that the star student, member of the Student Council, class president and co sports captain was a pathetic excuse of a human. They didn't know that he lived alone in a sad little apartment and made himself sad little meals because he couldn't cook to save his life. That he cried himself to sleep most nights and felt loneliness so deep and so vast that he felt he might drown. That he tried to erase his heart of the capacity to feel emotions because it hurt him to feel so deeply- and failed miserably. That he lost his beloved family to a car crash when in middle school and still had the guts to wipe his tears and show up for that competition and smile as he got back to the school a winner. He had contemplated telling Mydei a few times, but he knew that Mydei would think of him as so incredibly flawed and revolting for having the audacity to act like everything was fine that he would never look at Phainon again.

And now, even if he hungered for it, he would never be able to lay his heart bare and let Mydei choose for himself to stay or to leave.

That was probably the final straw before the dam withholding the true extent of his regret broke. Sobs wracked through his body, causing him to clutch his stomach and hunch over. Phainon found himself wrapping his arms around his body, trying to replicate the warmth of his family's hugs, but all he felt was the cold sting of reality. They were gone and now Mydei was too and there would never be anyone else who would wrap their arms around him and console him.

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Mydei rarely cried. He was not cold or unfeeling for he felt each emotion like a scar carving itself onto his back. It was simply because he shed so many tears when he was a child that there was very little left to shed now. His mother Gorgo had done everything to protect her boy from his father Eurypon- but there was only so much she could protect, his childhood slipping through the cracks of their crumbling family.

Gorgo was the strongest person Mydei had ever known. He remembered being a child and admiring her defiance as she argued against Eurypon. As he grew older, Mydei began to

understand the pain she must have felt when the love of her life turned unrecognisable. Even then, she stood tall and unwavering as she picked up the damaged pieces of Kremnos Industries left behind after Eurypon died.

Even then, he found himself furiously blinking back tears as he walked away from Phainon after he said goodbye. He cursed himself for not realising that Phainon was yet another person who only saw the 'prince' of Kremnos Industries and the gilded crown he wore.

Although, the child in him that remained immortalised in time believed that Phainon couldn't have meant his cruel words.

His mind was a mess the days after.

Without Phainon, Mydei felt lost for the first time in a very, very long time. He'd grown so used to Phainon's endless supply of smiles and annoying jabs that he forgot what he was like before Phainon. It had never occurred that there would be an 'after' to them.

And oh Kephale, it stung.

That infuriating smile he wanted to kiss, the steady hands he wanted to hold, the sun tattoo he wanted to admire and the snowy white hair he wanted to run his hands through seemed to taunt him from a distance.

It's not like they were ever his to cherish in the first place.

After Mydei's anger faded, he watched Phainon from a distance, unbeknownst to Phainon himself. There were times where Mydei had to physically restrain himself from demanding the truth- no matter how painful it might be- from Phainon. But something kept holding him back. Maybe it was Phainon's forced smiles or unnecessarily cheerful behaviour- far more practiced than what Mydei was used to seeing. Or maybe it was the hollowness of his eyes.

The ocean blue of Phainon's eyes seemed more like a trench than open water. The shine in his eyes had grown dull. (But was there ever any real shine to begin with?)

Somehow, Phainon still appeared radiant and put together. His boyish charm rolled off him in waves and Mydei kept second guessing his previous observations.

Mydei himself was not doing very well.

Apparently, he looked wan enough for the triplets he and Phainon would play with after school on Fridays to notice something was wrong.

And that was why Tribbie, Trianne and Trinnon decided to counsel him.

He sat on a pink swing meant for a child, his limbs jutting out because he was way too tall for this. Trinnon swung on the other swing in silence. Maybe this was her way of trying to cheer Mydei up. It did work, even if only a little bit.

"De?"

"Yeah?"

"Why don't you and Snowy talk anymore?"

"It's complicated"

"Nothing can ever be that complicated to drive you two apart and you know it."

Why was Mydei getting solid advice from a girl no older than ten while sitting on a child's swing? He had no idea, but this was his life now.

Phainon made life so much easier.

If his mother wasn't on a business trip at the moment, Mydei would have definitely sought comfort in her embrace and words. As he made his way back to his home, he heard footsteps falling in rapid succession from behind him. In a moment of vapid, helpless hope, he thought it was Phainon running over to explain everything. Unfortunately, he was proved wrong as Cipher, the Council's treasurer lazily waved at him.

"You look like you just got broken up with, little prince"

Wait. Was Mydei really acting like he'd been through a breakup? That was ridiculous, he and Phainon weren't dating.

He was sure Phainon didn't see him as anything but a friend

"That's absurd, Cipher. Phainon didn't break up with me."

Cipher grinned like Christmas had come early.

"Ah, but I didn't mention who broke your heart"

Oh, to blazes with it.

"Goodbye, I had a decidedly unpleasant time talking to you so I shall take my leave"

"Come onnn. Grow a backbone and fix whatever happened between you two."

"I said. Goodbye." Mydei gritted out before turning on his heel and speed walking away.

Fix whatever happened between you two, huh? Why a grand total of four people were so invested in his and Phainon's friendship was beyond him. It was over, no matter what he said or did, Mydei didn't think he'd ever get Phainon back. He didn't think he'd ever again sit next to Phainon in the park and watch the triplets play while sipping pomegranate juice out of cheap tetra packs.

"What you see in cheap pomegranate juice is beyond me, Mydei. Aren't you supposed to be, like, rich? So don't you prefer rich people stuff?"

"Deliverer, being well adjusted does not mean-"

"Ha! Only a filthy rich person would call themselves 'well adjusted'. For Kephale's sake, you're the bougie type of rich so I'd assume you would acquire a more dignified palate."

"Do you want me to fight you in front of children? Because your face looks incredibly tempting to punch right now."

"Awww Mydeii- you wouldn't want to hurt little old me. You'd miss me if I was gone"

"HKS. I would not."

Mydei was a liar.

He would miss Phainon if he was gone. He did miss Phainon because he was gone.

The seat next to him in the library that Phainon used to occupy felt empty- replaced by a void. So did his heart. When Phainon left, he took Mydei's heart with him. The worst part is, he had willingly given Phainon his heart, even if the other boy would never realise it. Mydei trusted Phainon with his heart and would let him do with it what he deemed fit.



It was Tuesday. And Tuesday meant a meeting with Phainon for the sports fest after school ended and everyone else went home. Mydei had already come up with a hundred things to say to Phainon once he saw him. He took a deep breath before pushing open the door to the meeting room.

All the words he had on the tip of his tongue failed him when he saw Phainon slumped over the desk, bloodstained lilies oozing out of his mouth.

The next few seconds felt unreal, like the air was made out of water and Mydei was trying to make his way over to Phainon when submerged. He shook Phainon's shoulder, desperately trying to get him to wake up.

What if he choked and died?

Mydei's breathing grew erratic at that thought and he wasted no time in checking for a pulse and if the lilies clogged Phainon's breathing.

At least he wasn't choking

He lifted Phainon off the chair and kneeled onto the floor with Phainon unconscious in his arms. He fumbled for his phone and called the ambulance as quickly as he could. Even in his feverish state of panic, Mydei knew that the school infirmary would not know how to treat Phainon, much less have someone present at this time.

It was like watching a horror movie come to life. Phainon had never before looked that… lifeless or drained. The sight terrified Mydei. His Phainon was exuberant, gorgeous and so full of life that you'd feel warm when he was so much as near you. As he waited for the ambulance to arrive, he pulled Phainon's phone out of his bag and searched through Phainon's contacts.

He saw his name list listed as Phainon's emergency contact- *my day mouse*, it said.

Mydei searched for Phainon's parents' contacts and dialed them. One ring. Two rings. No response. None of the calls were picked up. *Okay, this was fine, maybe they were busy or something.*

After what felt like an eternity, the ambulance arrived. Mydei stood up shakily, still carrying Phainon in his arms. Phainon was certainly not light considering that he was of the same height and weight of Mydei himself, but Mydei was strong. He could manage.

Mydei didn't feel so strong as he watched Phainon lying asleep on a hospital bed, hooked onto an IV drip.



Phainon dreamed of the first time he met Mydei.

It was on the day of the orientation for high school. Phainon had moved from the small town of Aedes Elysiae to the big city of Okhema because he got himself a full scholarship to Okhema High.

Across the street was a crying child with a small bruise on his arm, presumably from someone grabbing it way too tight. In front of the kid stood the most breathtakingly dazzling boy he had ever seen. A braid rested on his right shoulder and his blonde hair turned red near the ends. If this person wasn't the sun personified, Phainon would be damned.

He also happened to have a few scratches and bruises on his face and arms and an intimidating resting face, which led Phainon's brain to conclude that he was the one who hurt the child. The next thing he knew, he'd stepped in to fight the blonde haired guy.

"What do you think you're doing to the child?" Phainon gritted out before he punched the guy.

Phainon was a good fighter- the best in the town of Aedes Elysiae. This stranger happened to be the first person who ended up being just as good as he was. Fists flew and bruises bloomed on their bodies. For the first time in a while, Phainon felt truly *alive*.

"Stop fighting! Mister! Mydei's not the one who hurt me! They are!" The kid cried out, pointing to a group of bruised and battered teenagers slumped over a bench.

Oh.

So the pretty blonde haired guy was defending the kid. Phainon hadn't even begun his first day at Okhema High and he'd already messed up.

Wait, the child had said the blonde's name- Mydei. Mydei was a pretty name. He didn't think he'd ever forget that name; it was the kind of name that would stick with you for the rest of your life.

Mydei was glaring daggers at Phainon; no words were said, but the message was clear - *what the hell's your problem?* Phainon snapped out of his momentary daze and panicked apologies tumbled out from his mouth.

"I am so sorry I thought you were a bully and-"

"You thought I was bullying that child?"

"Yes, but- I'm new here and I didn't know you were actually protecting the kid. I am so sorry that I acted rashly please forgive me-"

Phainon tried to flash his winning smile that made most people falter and forget what they were saying.

But Mydei was not most people.

"That's no excuse to attack someone based off of an assumption"

Great, now the best fighter he'd ever come across thought of him as some sort of mindless brute.

That was how Phainon ended up making the worst impression on the first new classmate he happened to chance upon. Mydei still seemed to hold a grudge against him for beginning a wonderfully fine Monday with a punch to the face. Eventually, that turned to begrudging respect as Phainon made it his life's mission to get Mydei to forgive him. They got paired up more for assignments and sports classes after finding that they worked well together.

Phainon made sure to sit next to Mydei in the library that he visited every day after school. At some point, they became best friends. Somehow, being friends with Mydei felt different than all of his other friendships. Being friends with Mydei felt like summer rain. It was warm, homely and nostalgic at the same time. It was unexpected but never unwelcome.

Phainon had never known he could love rain this much.

When Phainon finally came to, his head throbbed like he'd just slammed it against a wall repeatedly. The beeping around him started to get on his nerves, so he opened his eyes to check for the source. He was then met with the golden eyed, blonde haired boy with the red tattoos like fire.

"Mydei" He breathed

"Phainon. You're awake."

He had never seen Mydei look so relieved.

"Haha… Well, I'm still alive and kicking"

Mydei snorted and didn't say anything else.

In that moment, the whole conflict felt stupid and childish. Like it all transpired ages ago. For a while, Phainon's head was clear, free of the overlapping voices plaguing it. Phainon assumed it was because of the medicines the hospital had put him on. Either way, he finally said the words he'd been wanting to say.

"I'm sorry."

"For what?" Mydei questioned like there was nothing for him to be sorry about. Oh Kephale, he didn't deserve Mydei. As intimidating as he seemed, Mydei was the kindest soul Phainon had ever known.

"For everything. The lies, what I said to hurt you and for avoiding you."

"Tell me, Deliverer, did you mean it when you said that you kept me around for convenience?"

"No. I didn't. I said it to distance myself from you."

"I'm assuming it's because you have Hanahaki and you didn't want me to know."

This was exactly why Phainon had tried so hard to avoid Mydei; Mydei had an uncanny knack for seeing the truth, no matter how much Phainon tried to hide it.

"I'll take your silence as a yes."

Phainon gingerly nodded.

"If you want to leave me and never look at me again, I get it. I really do get it."

"Don't talk about things that will never happen, HKS."

Phainon could have cried that very moment if he wasn't so tired and out of it.



"Mydei, I might be high because of the medicines they put me on, but there's a fat ass horse in the corner of my room and I think it's plotting my demise"

"A what now?"

"A fat ass horse" Phainon repeated impatiently, not unlike a little kid, gesturing to the get well soon card Hyacine sent him featuring her horse, little Ica.

"You mean Ica?"

"Yes, I mean that spawn of Satan. It has pure evil in its eyes. Evil, I tell you"

"I should tell the nurses to put you on a sleeping pill and knock you out, Deliverer."

"Mydei- Mydei- Mydeiiii- Mydeimos, noooo —don't leave me to get murdered by that thing!"

Mydei pinched the bridge of his nose and sighed wearily with the air of a man in his 40's who was suffering from joint pain, had gone through multiple divorces and was recovering from alcoholism. He met Phainon's watery blue eyes and decided that leaving him alone would be just as cruel as leaving a puppy out in the rain.

So he sat on the edge of Phainon's hospital bed, the bed creaking under the weight of two six foot tall seventeen year old boys. Phainon seemed to relax almost instantly and a lazy grin stretched across his face. At least he looked peaceful now; Mydei wasn't sure if he'd be able to handle it if Phainon looked the way he did when he was unconscious.

Phainon closed his eyes, still wearing that impish grin. To think he could one day lose this smile made Mydei's heart ache.

If Mydei could find the bastard who was making Phainon suffer out of unreciprocated love, it would be on sight. How dare someone not love *Phainon* , the personification of warmth and joy? Who stole Phainon's heart?

Why wasn't it him?

Of course Phainon wouldn't see you that way, you idiot. He cares about your friendship and you do too. Do not burden him with your feelings.

Even then, Mydei couldn't stop himself from asking

"Who is it?"

"Huh?"

"The person you have Hanahaki for."

It was like the gears in Phainon's brain skid to a halt as an unnatural calm settled over his features.

"You don't have to know."

"Deliverer, any more of this and you might *die.*" The words felt like poison to Mydei, bile rising up to his throat as he said them.

Phainon shut his eyes like the thought pained him and shook his head firmly as his response.

"At least get the surgery if you don't want to risk having your feelings not returned."

"*No.*" Phainon's voice cut through the air, sharp and certain.

Mydei was getting desperate. He would not- under any circumstances- lose Phainon. If need be, he'd pull Phainon back down from heaven or wherever it is you go when you die.

"Is it the money? Do you not have the money? I'll pay for it- you don't even have to worry about the recovery"

"I'd rather be dead than indebted to someone."

"Don't be so stubborn, HKS. *Let me pay for the treatment.*"

Phainon's easygoing expression was wiped clean and in its place was a cold, dead stare. It felt as if he was miles away and not right in front of Mydei. Somehow, this was the furthest he had ever felt from Phainon.

"*No- and that's final, Mydeimos."*

Mydei knew that Phainon's stance was final. He didn't want to cause a scene in the hospital, of all places by choosing to argue, so Mydei resigned- something he seldom did.

"Fine. So what's your plan then, Deliverer? Surely, you must have one."

"I- I'll figure something out."

"*Figure something out*, do you hear yourself?"

"Alright, so maybe I don't have a plan. What're you gonna do about it?" Phainon retorted petulantly as if Mydei was chiding him over doing something minor.

Mydei had to take a deep breath to calm down.

As much as he unfortunately loved this idiot, Phainon's the reason why his blood pressure would inevitably spike. To Mydei, getting a surgery if confessing your feelings wasn't an option was a no brainer.

But if it was for Phainon, he'd try to understand.

If he was Phainon, what would he do? The answer came to him almost instantly.

"Deliverer, why don't you try to fall in love with someone else? Someone who actually loves you?"

Mydei instantly regretted is words. He hoped he hadn't given himself away and yet, he willed Phainon to realise who he was referring to.

"Mydei, you're a genius! I can go on a blind date and try to get over that person!"

Apparently, he overestimated Phainon's intelligence.

"…"

"Is that not what you meant?" Phainon questioned, using all his strength to sit up on the bed.

"No, it's exactly what I meant."

"Alright! Operation get over the person I have Hanahaki for is commencing now-"

"-You're still in the hospital-"

"- after I get discharged!"

Mydei really shot himself in the foot with this one and he had no one to blame but himself.



That night, he traced the words of the get well soon cards sent to him by the Student Council after Mydei had informed them that Phainon was hospitalised. Mydei had chosen to stay with him in the hospital overnight. When Phainon had jokingly offered Mydei his bed to share, Mydei had looked as though sleeping on a bed of nails would have been more ideal. So, Mydei slept on a chair placed next to Phainon's bed- which was sure to be incredibly uncomfortable, but he didn't complain.

Fall in love with someone else? As if.

Not when Mydei made him feel like he *mattered*.

If Mydei cared this much for a friend, it made Phainon feel sick to think of how much Mydei would care for someone he'd fall in love with. Phainon just knew he'd be envious of that person; hell, he'd never be able to look Mydei in the eye without feeling that gut- wrenching feeling of pure jealousy.

If jealousy was an ugly thing, Phainon was the ugliest creature of them all.

Phainon got jealous easy because he knew he was insignificant. Easily replaceable and forgettable was what he always would be- with a pretty face to admire and honeyed words to cling on to. Mydei was the one person who made him think otherwise.

Through the dim lamplight, he watched Mydei sleep on that chair for a long time. His eyes roamed the swirling red tattoos that resembled flames curl around Mydei's body, his fingers aching to reach out and trace them. Sometimes, he wondered if Mydei was even real. This was one of those times.

The next day, Phainon was discharged from the hospital with a long list of prescriptions that they said would help slow the spread of the Hanahaki. Phainon had already mourned the loss of his budget for the entire month, no, maybe two months when he found out that Mydei had paid for his hospitalisation.

"You shouldn't have, Mydei"

"This is the least you could let me do for you. Accept it, HKS"

Phainon wasn't allowed to say anything else because Mydei simply refused to hear him out. At least he wouldn't have to move out of the flat- whose bills he would not be able to afford- and live in the woods as some sort of hermit as he had initially planned.

Mydei insisted on taking him back home and helping him out *because who in their right mind would leave a sick person alone, much less someone who's as foolishly stubborn as you*- Mydei's words, not his. Both of them would be missing a day of school, which was not something they did often.

One subway ride later, Phainon watched as Mydei rooted through his cluttered apartment, cleaning up the place. For the most part, Phainon kept his space clean. Except for the kitchen, which he rarely used. It wasn't Phainon's fault that he only trusted himself around a microwave.

"HKS, what do you even eat around here? Is the schools cafeteria food your only source of nutrition?" Mydei barked out as he looked through Phainon's woefully sparse kitchen cabinets.

Phainon took that very moment to pretend to be preoccupied with charging his phone and unpacking his school backpack from yesterday.

"Deliverer, care to explain why there's a drawing of a chimera lying on a pan? Surely you weren't that hungry so as to resort to eating paper."

A drawing of a chimera?

Oh.

Phainon scrambled over to retrieve the drawing of the misshapen chimeras he'd drawn the day this whole debacle began. He turned it over in his hands. He'd actually gone as far as to name the chimeras because he was bored. The one with two different sized horns was dubbed Coconut Beagle and the other one was Honey Fruitcake. He would rather die than admit he designed them (read: attempted to design) after him and Mydei.

"My chimera drawings! I was wondering where I left them."

"You drew this more than two weeks ago. Wait. Has this been on the pan ever since?"

"I shall choose to ignore that question"

"Deliverer-"

Mydei's voice had a calm menace to it.

"Are you telling me that you don't even *cook* for yourself?"

Phainon was really in it now.

"I- uh. No, I almost burned down my kitchen last time I tried so I kinda just stick to sandwiches and instant noodles"

"Why didn't you tell me that you couldn't cook for yourself?"

Huh?

Phainon was expecting to be reprimanded for being so incapable, but here Mydei was, looking…

Was that concern on Mydei's face?

"I'd have cooked food for you whenever you asked."

"That's nice"

"That wasn't a joke. I was being serious. You could have called me in the dead of night and I still would've made you food."

Phainon's brain took a moment to load this new information.

"Seriously?"

"Yes, seriously." Mydei narrowed his eyes and frowned, like he couldn't believe he had to explain it to Phainon over and over again

"Ah- well, thanks!" Phainon grinned and tilted his head to the side. He could've sworn he saw Mydei swallow.

"I'll make you some Golden Honeycakes." Mydei declared before getting to his feet and producing a grocery bag from under the dining table. Phainon had no idea when Mydei got the time to run to the grocery store when they were at the hospital, but he had long since learned to not question Mydei's ways.

He watched, enthralled, as Mydei deftly cracked eggs, stirred batter and made the best looking pancakes Phainon had ever seen in his life.

"You should consider opening a restaurant, Mydei. I'll be your first customer."

"Don't talk nonsense." Mydei scoffed, but he did look proud of himself- as evidenced by the small upward quirk in his lips. Phainon loved it when he could make Mydei feel happy.

Each time he made Mydei crack a small smile, Phainon would add a tally to the ever growing list like it was an invaluable treasure. He craved other people's attention, sure- but oh Kephale, he would do *anything* to make Mydei happy.

Mydei plated the honey gold pancakes and slid it over the small, rickety dining table to Phainon. Phainon didn't care much for propriety or manners the second he ate the first bite of the pancake. If he wasn't so hungry in that moment, Phainon would have found some way to preserve that masterpiece for all of eternity. Maybe he'd encase in resin or something- he's seen it done with other foods on the World Wound Web before.

Mydei was midway through his own plate when he cleared his throat to get Phainon's attention.

"Say, I called your parents when you collapsed. Neither of them picked up and I don't think they called you back either."

"Oh. Uh yeah- I- I'd be concerned if they did pick up."

"What do you mean?"

"They're dead. Anyways, what did you *put* in these pancakes? They're addictive."

Mydei didn't say anything for a long time. When he spoke again, his voice was uncharacteristically soft.

"If you don't mind me asking, when did this happen?"

"Middle school."

"Oh."

Phainon couldn't take the silence the room had devolved into, so he decided to spill his guts to Mydei. Why Mydei even put up with him after all this was beyond him. Maybe this was his last chance to get Mydei to leave now before he'd inevitably do so in the future.

"I was in school. My parents and my sister Cyrene went out for something and got into a car crash. I found out when I got back home." Phainon hated the way his voice wavered at the end of that sentence. He could still remember the police officers' pitying stares as he sobbed uncontrollably. His world was ripped apart that day- the pain came in waves. Each time he thought he might be okay, he was reminded of the fact that his family was really, truly gone and the pain began all over again. Over time, the pain subsided into a dull ache- or maybe Phainon had just gotten used to living with that pain.

He took a deep breath and continued "The next day was a sports competition- a basketball match. I went anyway and played and won and the whole time I was thinking that my family should've been there to witness it."

'You were so strong for doing that"

Phainon let out a bitter laugh. He felt the lilies clog up his trachea all over again, feeling helpless and small. Something was pressing down on his lungs so all he could let out was shallow, choked breaths.

"Strong? No, no- I was disgusting. What I did was repulsive. I had no right to pretend to be happy for winning when I lost everything. They'd have wanted me to mourn them, not pretend like they never existed."

Mydei got up from his chair and placed his hand on Phainon's shoulder, his gorgeous eyes looking straight into Phainon's. Phainon had memorised Mydei's eyes by then, but every time he was met with them, he still felt like it was the first time he was witnessing their beauty.

"Phainon. They would be proud that you had the strength to get up and keep going. I may never have met your family, but looking at you and the way you brighten every space you walk into, I know you were loved. You didn't pretend like they never existed. Your life didn't end when theirs did."

Phainon felt tears prick his eyes and he bit the inside of his cheek hard enough to draw blood. Lately, he was getting way too familiar with the taste of blood for his liking. The tightness in his lungs constricted ever so slightly.

It felt so, so nice to finally tell someone what was consuming his very being for the longest time.

"You're not in the wrong. You're not a bad person. Understand?" Mydei asked, his thumb softly brushing over Phainon's cheek. The person who made the phrase 'butterflies in one's stomach' clearly had no idea what they were talking about. Phainon felt like his stomach itself had defied the laws of gravity and his heart was beating so fast he thought it might bruise.

Mydei's hand was gone too soon for Phainon to properly register it as something that had actually happened and not as a figment of his overactive imagination.

"Yes." Phainon smiled softly

And for the first time, Phainon really did mean it.

The fluffy feelings in Phainon's chest were soon overshadowed by him violently regurgitating bloodied lilies into the toilet.

Mydei crouched behind him, wordlessly patting his back as Phainon gagged while extracting a lily stuck to the walls of his throat. Phainon gave a few dry hacks just to make sure all the flowers were out of his system for now.

Of course, his Hanahaki had to interrupt every moment he had with Mydei.

Attention seeking whore.



"You're gonna have to change out of that eventually, Mydei." Phainon gestured to the school uniform Mydei- in his haste- had forgotten to change out of.

Mydei wrinkled his nose in distaste as he looked at the uniform he'd had on for way too long.

"Yeah, I really should."

"Wait right here, I'll bring you something to change into."

Much to Mydei's horror, Phainon re-emerged with the much dreaded dromas purple pants and a shirt with a shade of yellow ochre so bright it was practically glowing.

"HKS, I thought Aglaea had you throw that out! Why do you still have it?"

"Oh come on, it's a good pair of clothes"

"Of course, because nothing screams fashionable more than a shirt so bright that could potentially blind the sun."

"Mydeiiii- I like it, though-"

"-And I don't-"

"Fine, I'll get you something else."

"*Good."*

Mydei had no reason to feel this nervous about wearing his best friend slash crush's clothes. *It was just clothes*, Mydei chastised himself.

With the same logic, Mydei also had no right to feel this… embarrassed about showering in Phainon's bathroom. He wanted the floor to swallow him whole for being this weird about it all. But just thinking about the fact that Phainon used the same towel sent an odd feeling through his stomach.

No, no stop. He thirsted over Phainon enough on a daily basis. Mydei was Phainon's closest friend, so he had to act like it.

So, Mydei decided to count every crack on the bathroom tiles as he dried his hair to ignore the fact that he was wearing Phainon's clothes.

Phainon's clothes, his brain unhelpfully supplied.

Don't act weird about it, his brain remarked again when he emerged from the bathroom to catch Phainon's brief glance at Mydei wearing his clothes, before Phainon inhaled sharply and turned around to go shower next.

You're his friend, don't do this, his brain was practically screeching as he made eye contact with Phainon who was fresh out of the shower, with his hair damp and trails of water running down his neck-

Get a grip, Mydeimos.

The rest of the day was remarkably uneventful. Mydei and Phainon spent most of it doing what they usually did. Such as hosting small competitions like who could stack the most books on top of their head and playing some games on Phainon's laptop, which was running on hopes and dreams and was probably on life support.

It hurt Mydei to see Phainon get up every now and then to cough up more flowers.

In the evening, Mydei offered to find Phainon some dates to get over this person- trying his best to not seethe with jealousy. It was ridiculous, really. Phainon was not obligated to like Mydei and they weren't even exes or anything like that.

Phainon's face fell slightly as Mydei suggested a few names that he could arrange dates with, but he quickly recovered- flashing a huge smile and nodding along.

He made Phainon dinner and made sure to pack leftovers for him to eat through the rest of the week and left.



Phainon watched as Mydei walked out the door after waving goodbye and slowly slumped to the floor, burying his face in his hands. He heard the flap of a paper before it jammed into his side. He let out a yelp as the paper cascaded to the floor. The paper was the drawing of the chimeras.

"Oh, Coconut Beagle, we're really in it now" Phainon mumbled to the drawing of the chimera. The deformed chimera replied with silence, as if to say: *really? this is a new low- insanity is what this is*. Which was fair- Phainon was the insane one, trying to communicate with a doodle.

When he and Mydei returned to school the next day, Phainon found out that Mydei had told the Student Council that Phainon had just tripped and fallen down a flight of stairs. Mydei

claimed that he had no choice but to sit with Phainon through examinations to check if he had broken a bone. Or several bones.

Phainon appreciated Mydei fro covering for him, he really did, but Mydei could have thought of at least a hundred other excuses for Phainon that made him look less stupid.

Beggars can't be choosers, Phainon reminded himself as Castorice shot him a concerned look and Cipher burst into laughter after hearing about his supposed tumble.

But oh Kephale, he wished he could choose Mydei as his date- even if Mydei didn't feel the same way. The dates Mydei had so graciously arranged for Phainon weren't going very well. To say that would be a massive understatement, but for the sake of his dignity, he described them as such.

Of the three dates he'd been on so far, one was trying to get over his ex, one had no idea this was supposed to be a date and one was just plain uninterested.

The last one hurt, because Phainon always thought he was decently good looking and moderately charming. He was starting to think those elderly ladies back at Aedes Elysiae were wrong.

None of them were Mydei.

He was currently on his fourth date. Or at least, he would be if his date showed up. He waited for an hour and then another until he decided that his date had officially ditched him. He sighed heavily, avoiding the pitying glances of other customers at the cafe as he sipped on the pomegranate juice with milk he'd ordered- it had grown on him.

P*oor thing*, they must've been thinking, *ditched by his date.*

Poor thing indeed, Phainon agreed, *the one he loves will never love him back.*

Would Mydei feel guilty at his funeral, Phainon wondered, if he realised Phainon was in love with him all along? Would he regret not loving Phainon back and live with that guilt for the rest of his life? Phainon wouldn't want that- Mydei should never have to be tethered by him, the dead weight.

Phainon was a dying star, he'd shine his brightest and inevitably explode; never would he be something great. Mydei was so much more- he was more powerful and brighter than the sun itself . Destined for great things, incandescent and fervid. Phainon found himself unable to resist as he was pulled into Mydei's orbit, rendered helpless by his gravity. He didn't mind forever being in Mydei's orbit.

But he was a terribly greedy person.

First, he wanted Mydei to look at him, then he wanted Mydei to love him.

Phainon was too absorbed in his thoughts to notice the overcast sky had turned darker. Fat drops of rain fell onto the pavement he walked on, before all hell broke loose. He found himself caught in the midst of a torrential downpour, cursing at himself for forgetting his umbrella at home.

Phainon sprinted through the rain and before he realised it, he stood in front of Mydei's house. He blamed his feet for carrying him there by accident- he definitely wasn't thinking about how badly he wanted to see Mydei. Definitely not.

He stood there for a good minute, contemplating and questioning all the choices that led him here to this very moment. Before he turned around to trudge through the rain, he heard the front door slam open.

"Deliverer! What're you doing here?" an achingly familiar voice sounded from behind him."You look like a drenched puppy, get in"

Phainon didn't argue and obediently followed Mydei into his house. Mydei didn't waste any time in flinging a towel and the clothes he'd lent Mydei a few days ago his way. The towel smacked him straight in the face as Mydei exited the room.

Once he'd changed, Phainon looked around Mydei's house. He'd been in here once or twice and each time, he was amazed by its opulence. Phainon used to think mansions were unwelcoming and intimidating to live in, but Mydei's felt strangely like home. The first place he'd been able to call a home since he left his own.

"What happened?" Mydei asked as he offered Phainon a glass of water

"I got stood up"

"Oh. You don't seem to be very upset about it."

"Yep, that's because I'm with you now!"

Mydei took the empty glass of water from Phainon and turned around, his ears slightly red. Maybe it was humid or something.

"I'd better get going now- the rain's stopped. Sorry for bothering you!" effused Phainon

"I'll come with you."

And so, Phainon walked side by side with Mydei, trying to avoid stealing glances at the blonde haired boy. Phainon jogged in front of Mydei before stomping on a puddle, effectively splashing water on Mydei's boots.

"HKS! What was that for?"

"Heh, gotcha."

Mydei scowled ,stormed over and kicked at the water to have it land on Phainon. Instantly, Phainon squirmed at the feeling of wet socks and pouted.

"Now why'd you do that? You got water all over me" He whined, shaking off the droplets of water that landed on his hair.

"Payback" Mydei stated simply before reaching over and helping Phainon brush the water droplets off his hair.

Phainon froze the second Mydei's hand touched his hair.

This was really happening.

Kephale give him strength.

Mydei's hand retracted from his hair a bit too soon and they stood in a painfully awkward silence. Phainon's eyes darted around wildly before they landed on the 7/11 he'd had a mental breakdown at in the middle of the night.

"There"

"What?"

"I wanna get something from there."

"Then buy it yourself, why're you telling me this?"

"Aww- and here I was, thinking you'd help a poor, starving man out"

Mydei ran his hands over his face and sighed deeply.

"HKS, in no way are you starving. You just devoured the food I made for you an hour ago"

"But that doesn't count, it wasn't dessert. My stomach has a special place for dessert."

"…"

"Please?" Phainon asked without trying to sound too desperate.

"Just this once."

Phainon hummed as he unwrapped a chocolate bar while sitting on the bench outside the store. Mydei had grumbled about having to buy this for him, but didn't seem angry. Out of the corner of his eye, he noticed Mydei gazing in his direction.

Calm down, Phainon, he's looking at your lips because you're holding the chocolate bar up to your mouth and he just wants to try some- Phainon mentally scolded himself

He held out the chocolate bar "Want some?"

Mydei blinked

Phainon impatiently waved the bar in front of Mydei's face

"I said, want some?"

" …yeah."

Mydei took a bite from the chocolate and muttered something about it being way too sweet, but Phainon wasn't paying any attention to that.

Mydei had just bitten off a chunk from where Phainon was biting into.

This led to only one conclusion:

They had just shared an indirect kiss.

If Phainon was a weaker man, he would have disintegrated on the spot.

"De! Snowy! You're back together!" Tribbie called out, running over to them, Trianne and Trinnon following suit.

Phainon snapped out of his daze and tried to ignore Tribbie unintentionally implying that they were dating.

He watched Mydei talk to the three girls and entertain them before they had to go back home. The girls must have missed Mydei and Phainon playing with them. Mydei looked soft in that moment, blonde hair that fell over his face looking golden as the last rays of the evening sun caught in it. He was unfairly good with kids- Phainon only knew how to smile and act childish, but Mydei was an actual, reliable caretaker. Instead of feeling envious of Mydei beating him in something, Phainon felt proud.

He felt proud that he was friends with a person with a kind soul and eyes that rarely smiled, but held a steady warmth. The constant suffocation of the flowers in his lungs eased up, if only for a bit.

He was so, so glad he befriended the boy with pretty eyes who reminded him of warm summer rain.



"Participants?"

"A few are absent-"

"-what? We told them to confirm if they could make it and everybody did! Why are they ditching last minute?"

"…" The fellow student, Cicero had no answer. Phainon sighed heavily, forcing a strained smile. He had an image to maintain, after all.

"How many?"

"One in the relay, one in the long jump and one each in the 400 and 800 meter races."

"I'll take their places."

"Phainon- that's four races, all consecutive. Are you sure?"

"Yes, Mydei and I have been planning this day for way too long for Okhema High School to not have a representative."

Weeks of preparation had culminated into this day- the sports fest. And Phainon was not about to let all of this go to waste. He would ignore the burning pain in his lungs and *win* for Okhema High.

Phainon was not going to let some stupid flowers stop him.

He stayed true to his word, running until his lungs felt like they might explode and he could taste the blood and flowers in the back of his throat. Mydei was just as, if not even more busy than he was, so it was unfair to ask Mydei to take up some of his events.

Phainon was on his last lap of the 800 meter race when he felt he might actually pass out because of asphyxiation. The cheers of the crowd around him swam in his head reverberated through his skull. He had to make it past the finish line. If he didn't, he would never be able to look the rest of the school in the eye. His legs cramped and his vision blurred as he lunged, exerting the last of his strength to reach the finish line.

Thunderous clapping and shouts erupted- *oh, I've won*- Phainon's brain strung together.

He thought he'd feel a lot less hollow.

Phainon pushed past the crowd to get himself into the shade, vaguely registering the pats on his back and applause. His vision swam and slowly darkened as the flowers surged up his lungs.

Ah. This must really be it.

His legs seemed to forget how to walk and he found himself surging toward the ground.

A blur of golden and red caught him and held him before he fell onto the ground. Phainon slumped against the figure, coughing and heaving. It felt so good to be cradled in someone's arms, so Phainon offered no resistance as he was dragged along and taken to a quiet corner of the bleachers.

He felt a hand patting his back as he threw up bloodied flowers. He collapsed onto the bench, still struggling to catch his breath and rested his head against the figure's stomach.

Slowly, he felt like he could breathe again and his vision returned back to normal. He looked up to see Mydei, fear etched onto his beautiful face.

"What were you thinking, HKS? Running four races, one after the other- do you know how *scared* I was when I saw you almost pass out after the fourth race? And don't even get me started on you running when you have Hanahaki-"

"But-I won.." Phainon heaved , his breath returning to normal.

"What's the point of winning if you have to suffer to win?" Mydei barked, seething with rage

"Worth it. They would've hated me if I didn't"

"Why do you think you have to push yourself to the brink of death to be *recognised*? You should never have to feel like you have to go above and beyond to earn someone's love."

"I-"

"No. Your body has its limits. *Listen to them* and never do something that would hurt yourself."

Oh.

When Phainon spoke again, it was in a voice softer than what he usually used.

"I'm sorry."

"Never do this to yourself again, you hear me? If you really don't care enough about yourself, at least don't do something like this again for my sake"

Phainon was about to reply, but he was cut off as he hacked another flower. Mydei's expression was pained as he watched.

"Phainon. For the last time, tell me who you're so in love with that you're willing to lay down your life. *Tell* me who that bastard making you suffer is"

"Mydei, we've been through this- "

"Then fall in love with me instead."

"*What.*"

Mydei dropped onto his knees in front of Phainon and looked up at his face with fierce determination, like he'd move the sky and earth just to make that wild possibility come true.

"Will you at least *try* to fall in love with me instead? I know you'll never see me that way, but can you please give it a try?I love you more than you could ever love that other person and I'll prove it to you as many times as you ask. I'll treat you right. I'll be everything that bastard isn't. I'll be whatever you want me to be, just- just give me a chance. Please."

Phainon's brain was working overtime as he tried to process what Mydei was saying.

"You really mean it, don't you?"

"Do I ever say things I don't mean?"

It was like something in him lit up. Nothing had ever felt so *good.* Phainon was floating on air, no, he was ascending to a higher plane of existence. The flowers that clawed at his airways seemed to clear up. He felt light and free, like a heavy burden had been lifted off his shoulders. Hell, the grass looked greener, the dull sky clear and the air felt wonderfully cool. He felt like his surroundings just went from a 240p to a 720p in terms of video quality. A huff of laughter escaped his lips and then, he was laughing. He couldn't even recognise the person laughing with unrestrained, pure joy.

He loved Mydei. And Mydei loved *him*. His bold, brilliant sun looked his way, saw all the cracks in him and decided he was worth loving anyway.

Mydei, who'd been watching him laugh with a wary expression spoke yet again in a tight, small voice.

"Give me an answer, HKS."

"That- that bastard you seem to despise is you, my dear Mydeimos." Phainon snorted out between bouts of laughter, lowering himself off the bench and to the ground where Mydei kneeled.

It was then Mydei's turn to gape at Phainon.

"…oh." was all Mydei got out

By then, Phainon was chortling, tears streaming down his face as he eyes scrunched up. Mydei slowly dissolved into laughter as well. His laugh was quieter and rough around the

edges, like he wasn't used to laughing. But Phainon swore up and down that Mydei's laugh was *lethal.* It would most certainly get him banned in pretty much every country for just how dazzling and hot and *beautiful* he looked while laughing.

The two laughed until their cheeks hurt. Phainon felt like a little kid again, unburdened and gleeful.

Mydei stopped laughing first, wheezing a little to catch his breath. Phainon looked at him and decided- *yep, that's him. that's the guy I want to grow old with.*

Without overthinking it, Phainon cradled Mydei's face in his hands, pulled Mydei towards himself and kissed him.

Mydei's hands went to his hair and held the back of Phainon's head as he kissed him back with even more intensity- like he was pouring out all the words he couldn't say. The kiss felt electric- Phainon was simultaneously freaking out and having the best day in his seventeen years of existence. Their teeth clacked against each other, but they were way too into it to actually care. Mydei's lips were everything Phainon had dreamed of and more; he was certain no human's lips could actually feel as soft as Mydei's.

After what felt like way too little time, Mydei pulled back to catch his breath. Phainon slowly opened his eyes only to have the breath knocked out of his lungs at how hot Mydei looked with his cheeks flushed and lips pink.

If Phainon died that day, he would die a happy man.

Mydei let out a sharp sound of surprise when Phainon pulled him back into the kiss like a man starving and kissed Mydei until their lips were red and swollen. When they broke apart, Phainon was the first to speak.

"Uh… thanks."

Mydei looked positively scandalised at Phainon's response, his eyes narrowing and a slight scowl on his lips.

"The hell you mean *thanks?*"

"I don't know what to say after kissing someone. Cut me some slack!" Phainon whined, well aware of how pathetic he looked in that moment.

"…I'm starting to regret falling in love with you."

"Mydei, that's so embarrassing for you"

Mydei looked seconds away from combusting either out of rage or embarrassment

"What is?"

"You're in love with me." Phainon cackled

"HKS, so are you!"

"True, but I won the competition. You confessed first, so you lost"

"Since when was this even a competition?"

"Good question. But I won"

"Son of a- fine. I concede. Just this once."

Phainon grinned, feeling like he was high. He probably was- Mydei was like crack to him and he was willingly addicted.

Later, they were tasked with tidying up the remnants of the sports fest after everyone had left. Phainon and Mydei made it a competition to see who could lift the most crates of equipment. Mydei won by a narrow margin, much to Phainon's displeasure. They locked the equipment room and headed out.

"So.. we're dating now, right?"

"What did you think all of this was for, then?" Mydei looked incredibly miffed

Phainon laughed lightly "I'll take that as a yes."

He kissed Mydei and laughed at Mydei's flustered expression. Phainon felt like the luckiest man alive to see the full range of Mydei's expressions. Mydei cleared his throat and hid the flush on his cheeks.

"I just remembered- we have to address what you named my contact. *My day mouse*, really?"

"What? I think it's perfect. I mean, you're *mine* after all, so *My* day mouse is fitting"

"You-"

The flush Mydei tried to hide earlier raged on his cheeks as he sputtered. Phainon couldn't help but tease him.

"You're blushing, Mydeiii" Phainon taunted before sprinting away at full speed, turning around to see Mydei chasing after him.

"HKS, wait until I get my hands on you-"

Phainon snorted, throwing his head back to laugh so hard tears streamed from the corner of his eyes.

He felt giddy and warm. It was then that Phainon knew that if he ever fell, Mydei would always be there to catch him and hold him and tell him everything would be alright.

It felt like he was finally home.

End Notes

So I got inspo from one of Mydei's chapters in As I've Written where they mention that there was a single bloodstained lily forming on the ground after he cried(at least, that's what i remember). Also, I like lilies they're cool.

I wanted this fic to be 7k words max, but nothing went according to plan and here I am now.

Works inspired by this one

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